The Butterfly Effect

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/58678444.

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Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Rape/Non-Con

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Additional Tags:
Non-Consensual Drug Use, Rape/Non-con Elements, Implied/Referenced Rape/Non-con, Past Rape/Non-con, Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Guilt, Shame, Self-Hatred, Betrayal, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Mentioned Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Mentioned Horde Prime (She-Ra), Abandonment issues manipulation

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English

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by SluttySnake69

Summary

Catra makes a friend during one of the best friends squads many missions across Ethiera, which leads to an unforgettable night. A night that leaves her with feelings of confusion, guilt, and uneasiness. Eventually, the feelings seem to consume her, and she confides in an unlikely friend.

Notes

I'd like to put a trigger warning for implied sexual assault. Really for the whole fic, but I marked the most graphic part. It doesn't get too graphic, I don't like writing scenes like that, but it can still be triggering.

It's marked to like this

See the end of the work for more notes

When Catra first heard the term 'butterfly effect' she thought it was absurd. One action can't determine the future.
Then she really thought about it, and now she thinks her entire life could be summed up with that one fraze.
She's had enough therapy sessions now to realize that if Adora hadn't found the sword, life would not be better, Ethiera wouldn't be better. Hell the universe wouldn't be better. She wouldn't be better off.
Still, on late nights when her mind won't quiet long enough for sleep to take her, she finds herself wondering what could've been, if Adora had never found the sword, and sometimes, she lets the fantasies swoller her whole, lets them convince her otherwise.

If Adora had never found the sword, the Horde would still exist, but maybe they would be on top, together. Making things better from the inside. Like they had planned. No one would have to leave. No evil space dictators, or clones, no boaring princess meetings, or royal court, or paperwork. Glimmers mother would still be alive because Catra would have never been sent to the crimson waste to die, she wouldn't be on a mission to, so she never would've pulled the lever. There wouldn't be a lever to pull. Mermista wouldn't have ever had to lose her kingdom, and Catra would never have to live with the guilt of taking it, Entrapta wouldn't have been sent to beast island.
Maybe it's not 100% realistic, but there's a lot less pain, a lot less guilt.
In theory, that is. But then what about King Micah? Still stuck on beast island, what about the universe? HE would still exist. What about Bow, and Glimmer? What about the best friends squad? It wouldn't exsist.
So neither would bfs sleepovers, and cake, and birthday parties. Glimmer wouldn't know her dad, Bow would still probably be hiding from both of his. Saleneas would probably still be falling apart, Ethiera would probably still be at war, and dieing, Adora would never know where she came from, or who she is. They wouldn't have access to things like therapy, and actually hot showers, and good food, and they wouldn't know any of their friends.

Adora, and her probably would have never told each other how they feel. How they really feel.
No one would have ever had to leave, but they would have still lost everything, even each other.

So no, she wouldn't be better off. However, lately it's a different butterfly that's been keeping her awake, it feels more like a swarm of them if she's being honest. What if she had never met Sieraly? What if she had stayed at the castle like she wanted? If she had just said she was sick, like her gut told her to?
Or what if she had stayed with her girlfriend, and enjoyed the rest of the party, instead of going back to that room?

What if she had decided to lock the door? Had went to hers instead?

That thought is enough to jolt her back to reality. She knows what comes after that thought, it's been months since the party, she's used to these thoughts by now. She doesn't think she'll ever get used to the guilt those thoughts bring. She curses herself internally for entering that room at least 50 times a day.

She sits up carefully, trying not to disturb her girlfriend whose sleeping next to her. As soon as her feet hit the floor beside their bed she can feel Melogs presence.

"You should tell her" they send. Catra still doesn't understand how their whole telepathic communication works, or why it only works for her of all people. If she thinks too hard about it it still freaks her out.

Without even turning around she knows the face they're making. She can feel them just about burning holes in the back of her head. She turns around to shoot them a glare, if anything it's to prevent her head from bursting into flames.
Since the moment she returned from Aquaphya, they've been insistent that Catra talk to someone. They know somethings wrong, they felt it the minute it happened, being emotionally tethered to one another tends to have that affect.

'You don't even know what happened.' Catra is quick to remind them. It's true, as insistent as they've been, Catra hasn't spoken about what happened in Aquaphya to anyone.
She's wanted to, stars she still wants to. There are times when she feels her head might explode if she doesn't tell someone, but as much as she wants to, she just can't. She just can't get herself to say the words.

Melog just gives her the 'are you for real' look.

She scoffs and turns away, tuning them out. She gets up and walks to her and Adora's bedroom door, twisting the knob as she shuts it behind her, trying to stay as quiet as possible.

--

"It'll be fun!" Glimmer insists. They're in Catra's office discussing the details of the trip to Aquaphya, a small kingdom just north of Saleneas.
Catra ignores glimmer, in favor of going over the copy of Glimmers proposal of alliance she wrote for her yesterday morning.
She does not want to take a trip to a Kingdom literally surrounded by water, she's had her fill of that to last multiple lifetimes. Water still makes her uneasy after her "conditioning".
She shudders at the thought.

"Absolutely not." She says shortly, still pretending to read over Glimmers skript.
They decided before they can start helping other planets, they should start rebuilding their own.
Now that they're coming up on their 2 year post war anniversary, the bfs goal is to leave Ethiera by the 3rd year post war. Which means they need more help in regards to the rebuilding.

So far they've managed to relocate all of the clones, including Hordak, Entrapta took them in, which honestly Catra should have seen coming. Almost all of the Horde, thanks to Perfuma and Scorpia, and the rest ended up either with Entrapta, or in the Crimson Waste.

As far as rebuilding goes, they're almost finished with the deconstruction of the fright zone, soon to be the Scorpionie kingdom, and have started the rebuilding of Saleneas, Catra made sure to put that at the top of the list.
Frosta, having the largest kingdom has offered refuge and aid to anyone in need of it while their homes, cities, villages, kingdoms, ect. are rebuilt.

There is little the bfs can offer now, besides supplies, and a place to stay. Except, they need a little more help. Even with all the princesses offering their kingdoms, and what supplies they can, as well as volunteers in regards to the rebuilding efforts. There's only so much space, and so much they can offer. Especially if the bfs plan on leaving. They need more help.
Which is exactly why Catra suggested expanding the princess alliance to much smaller kingdoms, with princesses who don't have runestones.

They're first stop? Aquaphya, ruled by princess Sieraly.
Why this kingdom in particular? It's the biggest, with the most influence. As far as Catra can tell it has the best reputation and most influence over the other smaller kingdoms. If they can get Sieraly, it should be a piece of cake getting the rest to follow.
It's also located in a pretty convenient spot, getting supplies to other kingdoms will be a lot more efficient with Aquaphya's help.

"Oh, come on Catra, please!" Catra's ears pin back at the shrill tone. Seriously, this girl talks in frequencies only dogs should be able to hear. Catra's like 80% sure Glimmer's doing it on purpose at this point.

She sets her paper down on her desk to send her friend a warning glare.

Glimmer either doesn't take the hint, or ignores her.
"We'll have fun. I promise. Besides you know I'm not good with scripts! What's the point in having you as my royal advisor if you aren't there to... To.. uh" She stops, her brows pulling together, she squints her eyes, "you know" she gestures wildly at nothing

as Catra raises both her eyebrows at her. "Advise me!" She snaps her fingers smiling widely.

Catra just rolls her eyes, picking up a discarded paper on her desk, looking for anything else to do then have this conversation. "You know I don't do water."

"You wouldn't even have to get in! You could stay in the castle, with Adora. It would be like a couples vacation!"
She gives her a flat look in response. "Think about it, just you and your girlfriend, alone, undisturbed, nothing to worry about or do.... Except eachother~" she says wiggling her eyebrows.
Catra feels her face heat up.

"Shut up" she shoves at her as she cackles and just teleports to her other side.

"Seriously, though, I'm begging. Please come. You know I love Adora, and Bow, but when it's just us three I always just kinda end up feeling like a third wheel, y'know" Catra knows that feeling all too well unfortunately. She can feel herself starting to cave, and she despises it.
"But when you're there, it's not like that. You know how Bow and Adora can get when they're together. They're... idiots." Catra can't help but laugh at that. "See, you get me. Weirdly enough. You're my best friend, and as my best friend, I am begging you," she claps her hands togther dramatically, "please don't leave me there alone!"

It's silent for a moment, Catra already knows she's lost this battle, Glimmer still hasn't moved, creeping closer.
Finally, Catra sighs clenching her fists and looking up as if pleading with the stars she won't regret this.
"Fin-"

"THANK YOU THANKYOUTHANKYOU!" Glimmer squeals, wrapping her in a crushing hug.

Catra nearly jumps out of her skin at the sudden contact, pushing her away.
It's apparent the stars either didn't get the message, or have abandoned her completely.

--

Catra's pulled from the memory when her claws are suddenly met with open air instead of the walls of the castle. She blinks and finds herself looking at her office door, opened. Surprised to see the crystal on her desk on.
She figures she must have accidentally left the light on and door open when she left earlier today, or yesterday she supposes. She's been doing that recently, more spacey then normal. It's like she blinks and hours have passed.
She goes to tap the crystal off, but before she can her eyes catch on the open folder on her desk. It's weird, she's normally a lot more organized. She immediately regrets it when her eyes skim the first few words.
"Aquaphya was a"
The report she had started. She only got three words in. She can't seem to finish. She knows what she should write, what she's supposed to write. For some reason she's having trouble putting the words she wants, rather than the words she means. It feels like a lie.

Aquaphya was a surprise. Princess Sier- was very welcoming, and generous. It had a nice climate, and the wildlife was thriving, crops were all well, and only few past issues were reported. Seas were calm, perfect for travel and transportation-

Or something like that. She knows it's what Adora would say. Hell 90% percent of that was just paraphrasing Adora.
It's not a lie, but it's also not the truth

--

2 months.
That's how long they planned to stay. That's how long Sieraly insisted they stay. She claimed she wanted them to see her kingdom, to have a better understanding of it before she made a decision.
The only thing Catra has seen so far is sand, lots of sand, and water. Too much fucking water. Her kingdom was very blue, and purple. Similar to brightmoon, except instead of pastels, it was plain blue, (not pastel??), purple, green, and yellows. The castles walls and ceilings seemed to be made out of sandstone, and shells. They were all rounded and smooth, except the towers which were gold and looked as if made from the horns of giant narwhals. The windows were all rounded, and lacked any sort of glass.

Adora and Catra were unpacking in there guest room, which had a large, eggshell colord balcony, which also lacked any doors or glass, it had a "railing" which barely came up to Catra's knees, and was made out of coral. The only type of door they had besides their actual bedroom door, was curtains. The balcony had a curtain instead of a door, the bathroom didn't even have that, it just had a wall separating it from the main room. The bathroom was also round, and an eggshell white. The room itself was a light blue, reminiscent of the ocean, which they had a full view of. Their bed was round for fucks sake!

While Adora gushed over the scenery, Catra was trying to distract herself from the ever constant ocean smell wafting in through the non existent open door, and windows. Laying on the very round, very eggshell white bed, she threw her arm over her eyes.

She was already cursing Glimmer for insisting she come along. They hadn't even actually met the princess. She was too busy apparently to greet the guests she insisted stay for two months. They're supposed to meet her tonight, for dinner in the main dining hall. Catra doesn't understand how anyone can eat after spending so long on a boat.
The deal was she will officially announce her allegiance if they stay the two months, and she wants to throw a big party with the

whole bfs there when she does announce it. If they don't, no deal.

Great, stuck here for the next two months. This is gonna be just great.

--

Catra actually didn't hate Aquaphya. It was kinda pretty, okay, it was gorgeous. Once you get past the surrounded by the ocean, nothing but ocean and sand for hundreds of miles, and smell of ocean 24/7 that is.

Sieraly wasn't too bad either.
She was blue, with wide violet eyes that had streaks of blue and gold, her skin was a light, sky blue that got darker at her hands and her pointed, webbed ears, and she had specks of white across her face, and skin. Almost like she was imitating the clouds in the sky. Her hair was long, and curled slightly at the ends in waves, it was white, like her freckles.

Her clothes were different too, all thin sheer fabrics, almost like curtains she had DIY'ed into makeshift dresses, flowy pants, and tops.
Funny enough she also didn't seem to care for any type of footwear.
She made a comment about it, the first time we had spoken,

"Ugh, aren't shoes just the worst?" She had smiled, looking her up and down.

Catra told her they were uncomfortable because she couldn't feel the ground beneath her anymore, it made her more off balanced, and she hated it, and that it was uncomfortable for her claws.
Her feet were webbed, and she had similar to say about that, they were uncomfortable for her webbs or something.

After that it seemed like Catra was seeing, and talking to her more everyday, and she didn't seem to mind all that much.

Sieraly was actually decent company, and after the first month, she would even consider maybe even calling her a friend.

They'd talk for hours in what started as the dining hall, then Catra's and Adora's guest room, and then, somehow, Sieraly's room.
Which was a lot different then any of the guest rooms. They ended up there when Catra was feeling more nauseous than usual. When Catra was snappy, and told her to go away, in some much more colorful language. Sieraly was patient, and offered to take her somewhere that "smelled less like sea" and had less windows apparently. Which was all Catra needed to hear.

That place turned out to be Sieraly's very own bedroom. It was huge, but it had no windows at all actually, it was in one of those towers, so it kinda made sense in a way. It did have a balcony, but this one actually had real doors, like solid doors.
The room was lit by different neon lights, she couldn't identify the source of. The bed was a deep pinkish purple, with satin sheets, it was still round though.

After that they'd just end up there. It was so much better then sitting in that strange room trying not to vomit alone, while the rest of the bfs explored.

It was a week before the big party, and they were sitting in Sieraly's room, when she brought it up.

"Aren't you and Adora supposed to be together or something?" The way she said Adora's name was enough to make her growl alone. She glared at her, as if dareing her to finish the thought.

She raises both her hands in a placating manner, as if surrendering.
"I just meant it's weird she's out with her friends and not here taking care of her sick girlfriend, if you were my girlfriend, I'd never just abandon you in a strange place, with someone I barely know, to go galavanting through the city with my friends." Her

words are full of malice, and clear judgement. She crosses her arms, and tries, and fails, to appear indifferent.

"She didn't abandon me" Catra snaps. Sieraly looks at her in surprise, clearly not having expected the anger. "I told her to go."

Catra stops and takes a deep breath, she's had many sessions about her anger issues with her therapist. Sieraly was probably just genuenly concerned.
She makes sure to say her words carefully this time, "She offered to stay. I'm not gonna make her miserable just because I am" she explains.

Sieraly's expression softens after a moment, before she looks away, chewing at her lip. "I still don't understand it. Not trying to be rude. I know it's not my business, but you deserve someone who'll stick around when you're sick, and take care of you without making you feel like a burden."

Catra takes several deep breaths. She'd be lying if she said she hadn't thought about it, that little 18 year old girl inside her, whispering that she's been abandoned again, on top of shadow weavers voice yelling at her this is proof Adora never really cared, and that this is just what she deserves.

Catra tries to think about what her therapist would say- Adora cared enough to offer, and then cared enough to respect her choice, and give her space.
She does care. She does care.

But Sieraly's voice echos in her head, and she feels the hurt sinking in.
V They sit in silence until dinner after that.

--

'Aquaphya was a'

Are the first words Catra sees when she's pulled out of her memory, she stands abruptly, knocking her desk chair over, it falls

to the ground with an earsplitting crash, sending the crystal on the shelf behind it crashing to the ground, Catra can barely hear it, her ears feel as though they've been stuffed with cotton as she rifles through her desk draw. She stops when she finds what she's looking for, pulling it out carefully.

She runs her fingers over the title gingerly, 'Ethieran Laws & Crimes'
She's thought of this non-stop since she returned, and she's terrified of what she'll find. She knows what she's looking for, she just doesn't know what'll be worse, that it's not there, or that it is.
She takes a deep breath, and opens the book, checking the table of contents, before flipping to the page she's looking for.

She finds it, reads over every definition, she feels her heart stop when she gets to the third classification.

--

It's the night of the party, the day before they're return to Brightmoon, Sieraly has officially announced her alligence to the princess alliance. Music is blaring, Bow and Adora have started an arm-wrestling contest between any guest they can rope into their idiocy, and surprisingly, Glimmer's off talking to not one, but two of the other princesses.

Catra should be happy, key word. Should be. Her therapist would tell her she should be.
But she's not, she's nauseous, and hurt, and lonely, and a little angry, and wants to just be with her girlfriend.
She feels abandoned.

She's had enough of just standing in the corner alone, she finishes her glass of champagne, and heads over to where Sieraly is talking to another princess.

Sieraly spots her almost immediately, and finishes her conversation.
When she turns to look at her, Catra says, "I feel sick, is it alright

if I use your room for a bit?"
Sieraly looks to where Adora and Bow are, and Catra can feel the anger bubbling up, she gives Catra a sympathetic look.
"Of course you can, I can come with you if you want? So you don't have to be alone?"

"No, I think I'd actually like to be alone right now thanks" Catra says shortly, walking away quickly so she doesn't have to see the look of pity.

When she gets to Sieraly's room she thinks about locking the door, then remembers it's not exactly her's, so that would probably be rude or something.
Still, she feels angry enough she could break something, she's tempted to. Instead, she just throws herself face first in the bed, screams into the satin pillow, and kicks her feet against the stupid round mattress.
And then, in a moment of weakness you couldn't waterboared out of her (and she says that from experience) just bursts into tears. It's so embarrassing, but it feels so good, she never wants to stop. She doesn't think she could even if she tried.

When the tears have dried she just feels sorta empty, tired, still hurt, just ran out of tears. She flips onto her back and stares at the ceiling, swiping at her eyes.
Normally crying like that makes her feel at least a little better, brings just a little relief.
She's just so tired of being abandoned, even though logicaly she knows that's not what's happening. It's just everything from the past two months catching up with her. It's harder than normal to listen to the logic.

She hears the door creak open and barely moves a muscle, she can tell who it is just by the sound of her footsteps.
Catra throws her arm over her face. "I thought I told you I wanted to be alone" she tries to groan, and hates the way her voice cracks around the edges, the hoars tone giving her away.

She feels the mattress dip beside her as Sieraly comes to rest against the headboard next to her.
"You are in my room." There's amusement, and something else hidden in her voice Catra quite frankly doesn't care enough to try to place right now. "Besides, I was worried about you. Wanted to make sure you were okay."

Tears prick Catra's eyes at that, just when she thought she ran out. All the sudden she's very thankful for the arm covering her eyes. But it can't hide the ugly twist of her face.

Sieraly doesn't comment on it, and Catra feels very grateful for that.
"You still feeling sick?" Concern, and again that thing she can't identify laced into her every word.

After a moment, Catra nods her head, she still hasn't uncovered her eyes.
"I have something that might be able to help with that," Sieraly says, and then there's the ruffle of fabric, before she taps Catra's arm, prompting her to look. Catra peeks out from under her forearm, and is met with four white pills in the palm of Sieraly's hand.

She sits up beside Sieraly confused.

"They help me relax." She explains, when Catra just squints her eyes she continues, "Why do you think my room is the only one without windows and has an actual door?" She raises her eyebrows. Gesturing around the room.
"The ocean smell gets a little old when your around it 24/7."

Catra never thought about it like that. She looks to the pills still in the other women's hand hesitantly.
Sieraly rolls her eyes, "Stars, they'll help you relax, what do you think I'm trying to poison you or something?" She seems offended by this.

Catra just shrugs, because, maybe. It would be one of the least surprising things that's ever happened to her honestly.

Sieraly's eyes soften, "look, I really am just trying to help, it'll make you feel better, help you sleep better to."

That sounds really nice, sleep would be nice, Catra wouldn't have to think, or feel anymore.

Hesitantly, she takes them. Swallowing them all without water. It leaves that weird feeling, like somethings stuck in her throat, but she doesn't care right now.

"There, see? You'll thank me later."

Catra doesn't even respond. Just scoots back down to lay on the bed fully, staring at the ceiling.

"It may take a few minutes to kick in" she here's Sieraly say, it seems far away though. She feels her scoot down to lay beside her on the bed after a minute.

The minutes tik by, and her eyelids grow heavier and heavier with each passing minute. She feels arms wrap around her, and her being pulled against the body they're attached to.
Someone says something but she can't make it out, her eyes finally shut, and everything is black.

She wakes up to a darkly lit ceiling, looking around, her body feels heavy, she can feel hands in places they aren't supposed to be, and someone is saying something but it's too muffled to understand. She tries to move to push them away, but her body won't move, and her eyes shut and she's met with an endless void of darkness once again.

She wakes up to the same thing, so many times she can't even count.

When she finally wakes up enough to move she's alone again. Her body still feels heavy, but not unbearabley, or so heavy she can't move. She moves her head first, looking around to what she knows now is Sieraly's bedroom. She stares at the ceiling, looks down to see the waistband of her tights moves awkwardly, kind of like in a wave shape. Something in her feels wrong. Her eyes sting, and still feel heavy, and sore. She feels groggy, like she could sleep for a week. She isn't sure she ever wants to fall asleep again though.

She sits up slowly, every muscle in her body hurts, when she stands up she's met with more pain. Her hands shake slightly when she adjusts her waistband, and she hates it.
She's sore, all over, and she hates it. She hates this room, and this bed. She wants Adora. She wants to go home.

When she steps out into the hall her eyes are assaulted by the light flooding in through the round open windows, closing them doesn't even stop the ache, she has to cover then with both hands.

She stubbles down to her and Adora's guest room. When she opens the door, Adora is still asleep in the bed, she locks the door behind her.
She crawls in next to her, wrapping her arms around her girlfriend, who stirs.
"Mhm, Catra?" She says groggily, "what time is it?" When Catra doesn't answer, she slurrs "where were 'ou? I 'as so worried, Sieraly said you drank too much." Catra suppresses a shudder, "'ats not like 'ou."

All Catra can get out in response is "I feel sick"

Adora seems to wake up more at this, sitting up a little and speaking more clearly. She wraps her arms around her and it's loose, and feels safe and so different then whe-

"Are you okay? You sound upset. What happened baby?" She asks gently, and there's no hidden tone, or secret meaning, just Adora careing.

She feels the fur under her eyes start to dampen, she sniffles.

"Cat? You're crying, what's wrong?" Adora brushes her fingertips so, so fucking gently under her eye, still holding her against her chest with one of her arms.

Catra just shakes her head, she doesn't know what to say. Nothing happened, she shouldn't be upset. Sieraly is her friend, and Adora's friend, and a princess. It doesn't matter because nothing happened.

"It's okay, I'm here, it's okay," Adora sooths softly, brushing her lips against the top of Catra's head.

"Sshh, it's okay, it's okay. I love you", why is that so familiar..

('sshh shhh, just relax, relax. I love you, you know that')

She feels her shoulders start to tremble slightly.

-

Catra doesn't really remember packing, or leaving. She just remembered her body tensing when Sieraly went in for a hug goodbye, and the itchy feeling it left on her, even after they were miles from Aquaphya

--

The first thing Catra sees when she comes back to the present is the definition in her book, and it just about sends her right back.

ETHIERAN LAWS & CRIMES

SECTION 8894 (Sexual Misconduct)

RAPE/SEXUAL ASSAULT

When a person is forced into sexual activity, or someone engages in sexual activity with a person who is underaged, or unable to give/take consent.

Classifications

When another person uses physical force/abuse of power/position over the victim.

When another person uses threats/blackmail/corercon against the victim.

When the victim is unable to consent due to intoxication, alcohol, drugs, sleep, age, mental compasaty. Whether said drugs, alcohol was taken of the victims choice.
However if the victim was unaware of the drug being taken, alcohol consumption, or mislead, that is a separate crime on top of the sexual misconduct.

The next thing her eyes focus on is the iron grip she has on the book, her claws have already torn through several pages, they're water marks all over the pages, and for the first time she realizes how damp the fur on her face is, when the ringing in her ears begins to dissolve, she can hear her voice echoing through her office.
The book is balanced on her knees, which have been pulled as tightly to her chest as she can get them without squashing the book against herself.
She can't stop staring at it, she can't stop crying. Her back pressed against the bookcase behind her desk.

A hand slowly sneaks into her line of site, resting on the top page of the book, it gently pushes it down.
It's just then that Catra realizes she can't breath, finally hears the gasps escaping her between the sobs. Her chest is moving so fast, and she's breathing so hard it's sneaking into her line of sight.

"Catra" it's a man's voice, it's familiar, gravily. "Catra? Can you hear me?" The hand tries to pull the book away, and her vice grip is back, yanking it towards her chest. She shakes her head, still staring at the open book, burning the image into her memory.

The hand lets her pull it back, but doesn't let go.
"Catra? Can you look at me?" Catra snaps her eyes up in the direction of the voice, and all the sudden she's staring into chocolate brown eyes, that look so much like the lilac ones she's grown to love, her friends eyes. The rest of his face comes into focus slowly, dark bushy eyebrows, crows feet at the corners of his eyes, smile lines, and Sun spots, salt and pepper beard, and long hair pulled back, half up half down to match.

She feels her breathing start to slow, "that's it, deep breaths. Breath" he encourages, and just as her breathing evens out, her hands are empty.

He sets the book down, open pages pressed against the carpet beside them, his eyes flash with concern as he reads the title, before turning back to Catra.
"Micah" she says it likes she's just, naming things in the room with her. Not asking him, just reminding herself.

This seems to only concern Micah more, she never calls him just Micah, even when he insists. It's always 'his Majesty' or 'King Micah', but never just Micah.
He understands why she may be apprehensive with him, he knows what happened, she told him herself. Glimmer explained it in much kinder words, explained her own part in it. They both carry a lot of guilt, and after hearing how she saved his daughter, he just couldn't bring himself to hate the girl. He thanked her even, for bringing Glimmer back, he's seen firsthand just how much she suffered for it.
Angela wouldn't have wanted that. He knows that. He didn't want that, still doesn't, she's just a kid. And so much like his own. He's actually grown rather fond of her, looks forward to when she'll have a conversation with him, maybe even tea.

The last six months, he's barely seen her. When he does it's at odd hours of the night, like this one, early morning meetings, or huddled in her office. She keeps forgetting to close the door, she always has this far off look. Like she isn't even there anymore. He's been concerned for awhile. Her other friends have been to, Glimmer was talking about it just earlier tonight.
She hasn't been herself since the trip to Aquateer? Or something like that.

He glances back to the book, his brows furrowing, he got a glimps of the page she was stuck on.
RAPE/SEXUAL ASSAULT
He looks back to her, and begs the stars he's wrong. She's just starting at him, that far off look on her face. Her eyes wide just, empty, her eyebrows relaxed. Her mouth is slightly agape.

"Catra? Can you hear me?" He asks hesitantly. When she doesn't respond for a minute, he tries again, his voice shaking a little, "Catra?" He's about to call for help, when her eyes finally blink, or brows furrow, and her mouth closes.

"Yeah, yeah I can hear you." She says softly, quietly. She opens her eyes, looking at him, really looking at him.

He swallows, begging, really begging he's wrong about this, "I need to ask you a very serious question, and I need you to be very honest with me." She looks a lot more alert now, scared even. He softens his voice, "I'm not mad at you, no matter what you say. Okay?" She nods, hesitantly. "And I want you to know, I'll believe whatever answer you give me. Okay." Her brows set as she nods.
"Okay, did. Did something.... Did someone hurt you?"

She stops, her eyes go wide, he can see her start to shake as her eyes dart anywhere but to him.
He waits, very patiently.
She stops, stares at a random spot on the wall, takes one more shakey breath, that rattles when she inhales, and nods her head.

Micah exhales sharply, he feels like he just had the wind knocked out of him. She still won't look at him.
"Okay" he says after a long pause, "was it during your trip?" He asks carefully. She squeezes her eyes shut, and nods again.

He knows he needs to ask the next question, he knows the answers already been given, he still, begs to anything that'll listen, that he's wrong.
".....Catra?, were,, were you. Did somebody assault you, sexually?" He hates the words before they even come out of his mouth, he hates them even more when he sees the way her face scrunches up in pain.

"..Yes" she gasps it, like it's been clawing at her throat for decades, it rushes out. Almost like it's been punched out of her. Suddenly her eyes snap open, and it like she opened the flood gates, tears are streaming down her face, there's no break in the streams. Her shoulders aren't shaking, or face isn't twisted like she's crying. She's crying like she's been holding it in and the tears had no were else to go but out.
And then she's talking, rambling, so fast he's afraid she might pass out.
"She gave me something before, I don't, I didn't ask, she said it would help me relax, and I felt so, I didn't . I knew I shouldn'tve but I took it, and then I couldn't move or stay awake, but I kept waking up, and I could feel it, and and, I shouldn't have taken it, cause now I know I swear I remember it, but I don't know what she gave me, and I took it. I shouldn't have taken it. I was in her room I was I was-"

Micah doesn't know what to do, he grabs her face and pulls it to look at him, "hey, hey. Look at me." She stops, her breath catching.
"It was not. You fault." She just stares at him for a moment, before the sobs start again, and then she's pulling him towards her, he wraps his arms around her.
"It wasn't your fault, it wasn't your fault. I believe you. It wasn't your fault," he whispers, her sobs increase with each word.

It's terrifying, and heartbreaking, all the time he has grown to know, and love this kid he has never seen her cry, period. The closest he's ever seen her is when she "confessed" to him, and told him she would understand if he locked her up and "threw away the key".
She had also never let him close enough to touch her, let alone hold her while she sobs.

They just sit like that, for what feels like hours. He rubs circles into her back, meant to be soothing while she lets out all the pain of the last eight months.

--

When Adora wakes up, Catra is already up, that isn't abnormal for her, as of the last six months. Adora wakes up, and Catra will be staring at the ceiling, looking miles away. She's been concerned about her since the morning they left for their return to Brightmoon.
However this is different, she's sitting up this time, her eyes focused, actually seeing the wall in front of her. Her eyes are red, and puffy, the fur on her face is still matted. She must have been crying.
Adora sits up, suddenly wide awake. Did she have a nightmare? If it was as bad as it looks, normally Adora will wake up.
She'll hear her, did she sleep at all? She looks like she hasn't slept in weeks, it scares Adora that she wouldn't be surprised if that was the case.

"I need to tell you something." Catra's hoars voice interrupts her spiraling. How did she not wake up, that's the, I've been scream sobbing voice.

Adora sits all the way up at that. "Okay" she breathes.

Catra still hasn't taken her eyes off the wall, melog has shrunk to fit in her lap, her hand lightly running over his coat. His mane is black, with streaks of yellow, and ripples of orange. Adora has only ever seen Melog's fur black a hand full of times. When prime

is involved. Or when she's having a really bad flashback involving Shadow Weaver, but Shadow Weaver mane is more of an ashe color, spiked with red, this is deep black.

"You have to promise you won't get mad." She says, and it's the way she says it that has me on edge.

"Catra-" "Please," she cuts her off before she gets the chance to finish her sentence.
Adora doesn't want to make a promise she can't keep, she doesn't even know what it is. But the way she said please, somehow, she just knows it won't be her she's angry with. Cause that's the voice she uses when she's blaming herself for something she shouldn't be, and Melog's mane is only evidence of that.

"Okay, I promise." And she means that.
She closes her eyes, and nods her head.

"...do you remember the morning we left Aq-Aquaphya?"

--

The Butterfly effect, is something Catra thinks about often.
If she had stayed at the castle, if she had went to her own room, if she hadn't had taken those pills.
She wouldn't have years of therapy ahead of her, she'd hate herself a little less, she wouldn't be as afraid to sleep at night, take medication, vacation, visit places for long periods of time.

She wouldn't have to live with the guilt, the shame, the hatred towards herself and her body.
But she who knows if she'd ever feel comfortable enough to have tea sessions with Micah, who knows how many other people Sieraly would have hurt before she got caught.
Adora made sure she went to prison for a very, very long time. So did Glimmer.
She wouldn't have been so close to them, would have spent the rest of her life not knowing just how much they cared, Bow to, of course.

What she had never told? Well she, again, wouldn't know how much the people closest to her care about her. And this person, that she had thought of being so big, so untouchable, so loved, and liked- she would have never seen her for what she truly is. Small.
After she came forward, as anonymously as possible. A lot of other's did too, and a lot of princesses that she had once thought idolized her, believed Catra, and took her side.
Does she wish it never happened? Yes. Would she change it if she could?
She's not sure.

Ask her again in 3 years.

End Notes

I have another fic for a different fandom that deals with SA, but this one is important to me. It's based off one of my own stories, with one of my abusers.

Except I didn't have an Adora, and it took me almost 3 years to tell someone. It was extremely cathartic to write, and I really hope you enjoyed it, stay safe out there.

And for anyone who needs to hear it-

I believe you. It wasn't your fault. You could never deserve that.

<3<3<3<3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!